Tyeb Sheth answered the charge as best he could: ‘Of course you are there. But Gandhi is our man. He knows our language and understands us. You are after all officials.’

The Sahib ordered Tyeb Sheth to fetch me before him. I went to the Sahib in company with Tyeb Sheth and others. No seats were offered, we were kept standing.

‘What brings you here?’ said the Sahib addressing me.

‘I have come here at the request of my fellow countrymen to help them with my advice,’ I replied.

‘But don’t you know that you have no right to come here? The permit you hold was given you by mistake. You cannot be regarded as a domiciled Indian. You must go back. You shall not wait on Mr Chamberlain. It is for the protection of the Indians here that the Asiatic Department has been especially created. Well, you may go.’ With this he bade me good-bye, giving me no opportunity for a reply.

But he detained my companions. He gave them a sound scolding and advised them to send me away.

They returned chagrined. We were now confronted with an unexpected situation.